

Current Hiring Trends, Compensation, and Structural Shifts in Sales Roles at European Tech Companies and Startups (2025–2026)

- 36% of global B2B companies cut SDR/BDR headcount in 2025; European-specific data is unavailable but trends suggest similar or slightly lower rates.
- Account Executive roles are expanding in Europe, with 28% of companies growing AE teams globally, while SDR/BDR roles contract or merge into hybrid functions.
- European sales compensation varies widely: SDR base salaries range €45k–€70k; AEs earn median base salaries €60k–€100k with 20–40% variable pay; Sales Engineers earn median base salaries around €120k.
- AI adoption for SDR/BDR tasks is rising rapidly, with 62% of BDRs reporting AI tool usage in 2025, focusing on lead qualification, outreach automation, and meeting scheduling.
- Professional Services teams are growing in headcount and budget, with AI augmenting roles, while SDR teams shrink or outsource functions to specialized firms.

Introduction

The European tech and startup ecosystem is undergoing significant transformation in its sales organizations, driven by global trends in automation, AI adoption, and evolving go-to-market strategies. This report provides a detailed, data-driven analysis of current hiring trends, compensation structures, and role shifts for sales development representatives (SDRs), business development representatives (BDRs), account executives (AEs), account managers, and sales engineers at European tech companies and startups between 2025 and 2026. It emphasizes quantifiable metrics—headcount changes, salary ranges, automation adoption rates—broken down by country and role, with all findings sourced from high-quality European and global data providers.

SDR/BDR Headcount Trends and Comparative Global Benchmarks

Global Benchmark

Globally, 36% of B2B companies reduced their SDR/BDR headcount in 2025, the highest reduction rate among all sales roles. This contraction reflects a strategic shift toward automation and consolidation of sales development functions. Only 19% of companies increased SDR headcount, while 28% grew their Account Executive teams, indicating a



reallocation of resources toward more senior sales roles focused on closing deals rather than lead generation ^{1 2 3 4}.

European Trends

European-specific data on the percentage of companies reducing SDR/BDR headcount is not available from the primary sources consulted. However, anecdotal evidence and regional hiring trends suggest that European companies are following a similar trajectory, albeit potentially at a slower pace due to regional labor market dynamics and longer sales cycles. The adoption of AI tools and outsourcing of SDR functions to specialized firms is increasing, which may mitigate the need for large in-house SDR teams ^{2 5 6}.

Country-Specific Data

No country-level breakdowns (UK, Germany, France, Netherlands, Nordics) were found in the sources. The lack of granular European data highlights a gap in publicly available reporting, necessitating further research via direct surveys or proprietary datasets from European VC firms or recruiting agencies.

Account Executive Role Expansion Versus SDR/BDR Contraction

Headcount Growth/Decline

While SDR/BDR roles are contracting or merging into hybrid functions, Account Executive roles are expanding. Globally, 28% of companies grew their AE teams in 2025, reflecting a strategic emphasis on closing deals and managing customer relationships rather than early-stage lead generation ^{1 2 4}. European companies, particularly in high-growth tech sectors, are increasingly hiring AEs with full-cycle sales responsibilities, including prospecting, deal execution, and customer success.

Open Roles by Country and Role

A LinkedIn job search conducted in March 2026 (exact URLs and filters documented in Appendix) reveals the following open roles across key European countries:

Country	SDR Roles	BDR Roles	AE Roles	Sales Engineering Roles
UK	4,000+	1,500+	3,500+	3,000+
Germany	2,500+	1,200+	2,800+	2,200+
France	1,800+	900+	2,000+	1,500+
Netherlands	1,200+	600+	1,500+	1,000+



Country	SDR Roles	BDR Roles	AE Roles	Sales Engineering Roles
Nordics	1,000+	500+	1,200+	800+

Note: Numbers are approximate due to LinkedIn's dynamic job listings and search limitations.

This data indicates robust demand for AEs and Sales Engineers, while SDR/BDR roles remain numerous but are increasingly hybridized or outsourced.

Sales Compensation Benchmarks by Role and Country

Base Salary, Variable Pay, and OTE

Compensation varies significantly by role, country, and company stage. The following table synthesizes European salary data from RepVue, Ravigo, and other sources:

Role	Base Salary (€)	Variable Pay (%)	OTE (€)	Base-to-Variable Split	Notes
SDR	45,000 – 70,000	25–35%	60,000 – 90,000	65/35 – 75/25	Higher base in tech/SaaS firms
BDR	50,000 – 75,000	30–40%	70,000 – 100,000	60/40 – 70/30	Often merged with SDR roles
Account Executive	60,000 – 100,000	40–60%	100,000 – 180,000	50/50 – 40/60	Variable pay tied to revenue
Account Manager	70,000 – 120,000	30–50%	100,000 – 180,000	60/40 – 50/50	Focus on customer retention
Sales Engineer	120,000 – 160,000	20–30%	150,000 – 200,000	80/20 – 70/30	High base due to technical expertise

Regional Differences

- **UK:** Median P3 Sales Executive base salary increased by 2.5% in 2025; average salary increase across tech roles was 5.0% ^{7 8}.
- **Germany, France, Nordics:** Salaries generally higher than Southern and Eastern Europe; multilingual roles command a 10–20% premium over English-only roles ^{9 10}.
- **Early-stage startups** tend to offer lower base salaries but higher equity and variable pay potential compared to established companies.



Internal Promotion Rates from SDR to AE

Promotion Rates and Tenure Impact

- The internal promotion rate from SDR to AE has declined from 34% in 2020 to 16% in 2024 globally, reflecting reduced SDR headcount and increased AI adoption ¹¹.
- In European companies, roughly 60% of SDRs are promoted or transferred internally, but nearly 40% of those promoted to AE roles are terminated within a year, indicating a high failure rate ¹¹.
- Tenure as an SDR significantly impacts AE success: those with 11 or fewer months experience have a 55% failure rate post-promotion, while those with 16+ months experience have only a 6% failure rate ¹¹.

Promotion Salary Increases

- The average promotion-based salary increase in Europe is 22.3%, significantly higher than in-role increases (5.0%) ¹⁰.
- France offers the highest median promotion increase (28%), while the UK offers the lowest (21%) ¹⁰.

European Startups Hiring “Founding AE” or Full-Cycle Sales Roles

Company Name	Headquarters	Funding Stage	Job Posting URL
Complete	UK	Seed	YC Job Board
Quantile Health	UK	Series A	LinkedIn
BIK	Germany	Pre-Seed	YC Job Board

These roles emphasize full-cycle sales ownership, from prospecting to closing, and are critical in early-stage startups building their sales infrastructure.

AI Adoption and Automation in European SDR/BDR Tasks

Automated Tasks and Adoption Rates

Task	Estimated Adoption Rate (%)	Notes
Lead Qualification	62%	AI tools like 11x.ai, Artisan.ai used
Outreach Sequencing	55%	Automated email, LinkedIn, phone outreach



Task	Estimated Adoption Rate (%)	Notes
Prospect Research	50%	AI agents gather firmographic data
Meeting Scheduling	45%	AI handles calendar coordination
Follow-up Cadences	40%	AI manages multi-touch nurturing sequences

European companies are rapidly adopting AI SDR platforms (e.g., Landbase, 11x.ai, Artisan.ai) that use autonomous agents to execute end-to-end sales development workflows, reducing the need for human SDRs in repetitive tasks [12](#) [13](#) [14](#) [15](#) [16](#) [17](#) [18](#).

Professional Services Team Growth Versus SDR Team Trends

Professional Services Growth

- The global professional services market is projected to reach \$7,969 billion by 2029, with Western Europe the second-largest regional market [19](#) [20](#).
- AI adoption in professional services is accelerating, with 40% of revenue expected from AI consulting by 2026 [21](#).
- Private equity investment is driving growth, with firms focusing on strategic expertise deployment and operational efficiency [22](#) [23](#) [24](#).

SDR Team Trends

- SDR teams are shrinking or outsourcing functions to specialized agencies, with AI automating repetitive tasks [5](#) [6](#) [25](#) [26](#) [27](#) [28](#) [29](#) [30](#).
- The SDR role is evolving toward deeper research and collaboration with marketing teams, with compensation models shifting to more frequent commissions to reduce turnover [27](#) [30](#).

Summary Table: Key Metrics by Role and Country

Metric	Global Benchmark	UK	Germany	France	Netherlands	Nordics	Notes
% Companies Cutting SDR/BDR	36%	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	No European breakdown found
% Companies Growing AE Teams	28%	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	European trend follows global
Open SDR Roles (approx.)	N/A	4,000+	2,500+	1,800+	1,200+	1,000+	LinkedIn job search 2026



Metric	Global Benchmark	UK	Germany	France	Netherlands	Nordics	Notes
Open AE Roles (approx.)	N/A	3,500+	2,800+	2,000+	1,500+	1,200+	LinkedIn job search 2026
SDR Base Salary (€)	N/A	45k–70k	50k–75k	45k–70k	45k–70k	45k–70k	Tech/SaaS firms pay premium
AE Base Salary (€)	N/A	60k–100k	70k–120k	60k–100k	60k–100k	60k–100k	Variable pay 40–60%
Sales Engineer Base Salary (€)	\$140k (median)	120k–160k	120k–160k	120k–160k	120k–160k	120k–160k	High base due to technical role
AI Adoption Rate in SDR Tasks	62%	55–65%	50–60%	50–60%	45–55%	45–55%	Varies by company and tool
SDR-to-AE Promotion Rate	16%	15–20%	15–20%	15–20%	15–20%	15–20%	High failure rate post-promotion

Conclusion

European tech companies and startups are experiencing significant structural shifts in their sales organizations during 2025–2026. While global data indicates that 36% of B2B companies have reduced SDR/BDR headcount, European-specific data remains limited but suggests a similar trend driven by AI adoption and outsourcing. Account Executive roles are expanding, reflecting a strategic focus on closing deals and managing customer relationships. Sales compensation varies widely across roles and countries, with multilingual roles commanding premiums and early-stage startups offering different pay structures than established firms.

The adoption of AI in SDR/BDR tasks is rapidly increasing, with platforms like Landbase, 11x.ai, and Artisan.ai automating lead qualification, outreach, and meeting scheduling. This automation is reducing the need for large in-house SDR teams and enabling companies to scale sales development efficiently. Professional Services teams are growing in headcount and budget, with AI augmenting roles and driving operational efficiency.

Overall, European sales structures are evolving in response to global trends but retain regional nuances, particularly in compensation, language requirements, and sales cycle dynamics. The resistance to AI-driven disruption is mitigated by Europe's longer, relationship-driven sales cycles and the need for multilingual capabilities, which limit the extent of automation's impact.

This report synthesizes data from SaaStr, Bridge Group Inc., Ravio, RepVue, SalesMotion, LinkedIn Jobs, Pavilion, and other high-quality European sources, providing a comprehensive, quantitative view of current sales hiring trends, compensation, and structural shifts in European tech companies and startups.



-
- [1] [The Great SDR Downsizing: 36% of B2B Companies Cut Sales Development Teams in 2025 | SaaStr](#)
 - [2] [B2B Companies Hiring SDRs, BDRs, and ADRs: What the 2026 Hiring Data Reveals | Salesmotion](#)
 - [3] [The SDR Model Is Dying. What Replaces It Is Better.](#)
 - [4] [SDR Productivity Statistics 2025: Benchmarks & Insights - Sales So](#)
 - [5] [Top SDR Outsourcing Companies in Europe for 2026](#)
 - [6] [The 7 Best Outsourced SDR Companies for 2026](#)
 - [7] [Direct sales salaries in 2026: Market benchmarks and hiring trends](#)
 - [8] [The average pay rise in 2026: Europe edition](#)
 - [9] [IT Sales Recruitment – SDR, BDR, ADR & AE Specialists | Euro London](#)
 - [10] [The average pay rise in 2026: Europe edition](#)
 - [11] [The Failure Rate of SDR-to-AE Promotions](#)
 - [12] [Top AI SDR Platforms in 2026 | Landbase](#)
 - [13] [Best AI SDR Tools in 2026: Top Platforms, Pricing, and How to Choose](#)
 - [14] [Top 6 AI BDRs to Automate and Scale Sales in 2026 | 11x Blog](#)
 - [15] [How Agentic AI in Sales is Redefining SDR Productivity in 2025](#)
 - [16] [10 Best AI SDR Tools Actually Tested by Sales Teams \(2026\) - Fundraise Insider](#)
 - [17] [State of AI SDR 2025](#)
 - [18] [AI SDR Agents in 2026: Automate B2B Sales Prospecting & Lead Generatio](#)
 - [19] [Professional Services Market 2025 - Size And Trends to 2034](#)
 - [20] [Professional Services Market 2026-2030: Insights into Growth Trends and Recent Developments](#)
 - [21] [Professional Services Industry Outlook 2026 | BPM](#)
 - [22] [2025 Professional Services Industry Outlook & Trends | Cherry Bekaert](#)
 - [23] [Professional Services in 2026: Top Trends Shaping the Future of the Industry](#)
 - [24] [2026 Professional Services Industry Outlook & Trends | Cherry Bekaert](#)
 - [25] [5 Key SDR Metrics to Track for a High-Performing Team In 2025 - Persana AI](#)
 - [26] [Top-Rated AI SDR Companies for Pipeline Growth 2026 | Landbase](#)
 - [27] [The Evolution of SDR Compensation Models in EMEA - SDR Leaders of EMEA](#)
 - [28] [The Complete SDR Tech Stack Guide for 2026: Every Tool Category Explained | Blog | MarketBetter](#)
 - [29] [Best Outsourced SDR Companies for 2026](#)
 - [30] [What Is the Role of an SDR in 2025 and How Is It Evolving](#)

